His army began its return to Macedonia by sailing down the Jhelam and the Indus for many months and then via the sea and along the coast.

In Punjab, Alexander had met some ascetics that the Greeks recorded as ‘gymnosophists’ (naked philosophers). They had apparently given up all vanity and saw death with contemptuous indifference. They held ‘that all men are held in bondage, like prisoners of war, to their own innate enemies —the sensual appetites, gluttony, anger, joy, grief, longing, desire, and such like—while it is only the man who has triumphed over these enemies who goes to God’.[7] Alexander was intrigued and ordered their master, ‘Dandamis’, to come see him or else face beheading.

Dandamis bluntly refused. ‘Let Alexander terrify with these threats those who wish for gold and for wealth, and who dread death . . . Go, then, and tell Alexander this: “Dandamis has no need of aught that is yours, and therefore will not go to you, but if you want anything from Dandamis come you to him.”’ This raised Alexander’s admiration for the ascetics. He persuaded one of them to come along—‘Calanus’, a candidate for being ‘India’s first cultural emissary’. His fellow ascetics denounced Calanus for selling out and leaving ‘to serve another master than God’. Calanus later left a deep mark on generations of Graeco-Roman writers with his eerily calm public self-immolation after an illness, where he climbed ‘on his own funeral pyre’.[8]

It’s fair to say that Alexander’s foray had a marginal political impact on the subcontinent. Just two years later (323 BCE), aged thirty-two, he died in Babylon on his way back home, perhaps from typhoid. His death set off a war of succession. When the dust settled, some of his generals ruled different parts of his fragmented empire. Much of Asia west of Punjab was usurped by Seleucus Nicator, founder of the Seleucid Empire (312–63 BCE),

Meanwhile in Taxila, goes a popular legend, a man of ‘humble origins’ (which most likely implies lower caste) named Chandragupta Maurya was plotting to overthrow the unpopular king of the Nanda Empire in Pataliputra. Alexander may have met young Chandragupta and inspired him. His strategist was Kautilya (Chanakya to some), ‘a devious and disgruntled brahmin who had been slighted at the Nanda court’.[9] The duo forged political and military alliances and led a victorious war in which, claims a Buddhist text, ‘thousands of elephants, horses, charioteers, and